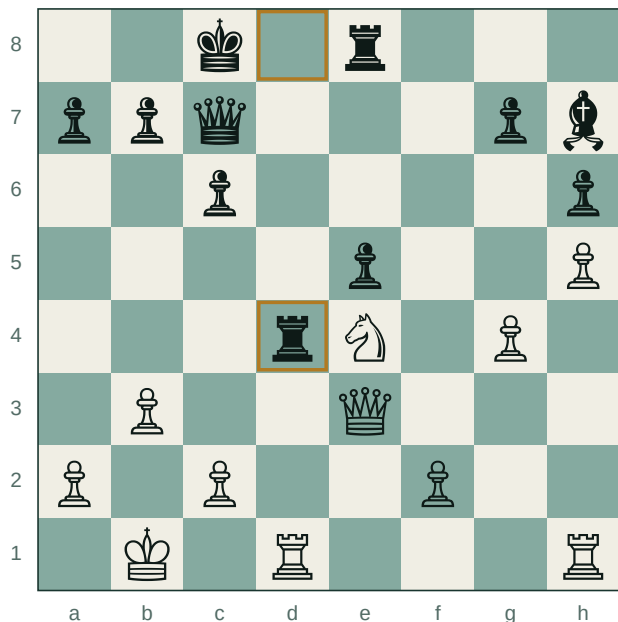


Queenside attacks: White, move 25

Queenside attacks

White to move



Previous move: 24...Rd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

25. Rxd4 exd4 26. Nd6+ Qxd6 27. Qxe8+

25.Rxd4 The rook captures the rook on d4. Recorded reply: **25...exd4**.

26.Nd6+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From d6 it attacks king on c8 and rook on e8. Recorded reply: **26...Qxd6**.

27.Qxe8+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on e8.

At the end, nominal material is White 20 / Black 18 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from +0 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The board's left half is not inherently safe. Queen checks and rook entries can make a queenside king as vulnerable as a kingside one.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An attack on the queenside can target a castled king, a vulnerable pawn, or trapped pieces. Files and entry squares matter more than simply advancing flank pawns.

HOW TO LOOK

Locate the critical target and which pawn or piece move opens a route toward it. Check whether central counterplay interrupts the plan.

The defending king is on c8. Geometrically undefended: rook on e8 and bishop on h7. Check for tactical protection.